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LANDSCAPE IN THE THOUGHT OF

SU SHIH (1036-1101)

by

ANDREW LEE MARCH

A dissertation submitted in partial fulfillment
of the requirements for the degree of

DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY

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UNIVERSITY OF WASHINGTON

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We have carefully read the dissertation entitled _____
Landscape in the Thought of Su Shih (1036 - 1101)

_____ submitted by
Andrew Lee March _____ in partial fulfillment of
the requirements of the degree of Doctor of Philosophy
and recommend its acceptance. In support of this recommendation we present the following
joint statement of evaluation to be filed with the dissertation.

This is an unusual, and unusually valuable, dissertation. Its central theme, landscape, is clearly and demonstrably geographic, and Mr. March effectively relates his treatment to the relevant body of disciplinary literature and argument. But the dissertation also deals, at a high level of effectiveness and sophistication, with important concepts in literature and the arts, philosophy, and psychology, and rests as well on an understanding of Chinese intellectual history. The skill with which Mr. March has woven modern psychological concepts into his analysis may warrant particular mention; he has produced a genuinely new approach, not only to the study of landscape or to the thought of Su Shih as an important figure, but to a host of similar problems in what has been referred to elsewhere as "idealist analysis", a matter common to many disciplines, including geography.

Su Shih is a particularly suitable subject for such an investigation, and Mr. March's work substantially increases our understanding not only of Su but of the China which he importantly represents and helped to influence, and, on a wider scale, of the role of landscape in human thought and action. The materials from Su's works which are included in the dissertation have been skillfully selected and competently translated, many of them by Mr. March himself in the face of numerous linguistic problems. In whatever discipline, the dissertation is valuable as a significant new contribution, resting upon important and well presented material and making use of a well-developed and in many respects a pioneering approach. Both its information and its analysis will be of benefit to scholars in the China field and in the other fields which it touches. As a dissertation in geography, it represents an important step forward in idealist analysis and thus helps to widen the horizons of the discipline.

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PREVIEW

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ABBREVIATIONS AND CONVENTIONS

Biographical references are to Herbert A. Giles, A Chinese Biographical Dictionary (London: Bernard Quaritch, 1896) ("Giles"); or, for people not included in Giles, to Fang I et al., Great Biographical Dictionary of China (方毅: 中國人名大辭典) (Hong Kong: 泰興書局, 1931) ("JMTT").

Translations are my own unless otherwise ascribed. "Trans. adj." ("translatum adjutante. . .") means that in making my translation I have been helped by someone else's translation as indicated.

The following abbreviations refer to the original texts of Su Shih's writings:

Ch'en: 陳邇冬: 蘇軾詩選 . Peking: 人民文学出版社, 1957.

Hu: 胡雲翼: 宋詞三百首 . Hong Kong: 香港上海印書館, 1957.

SPPY: 東坡七集: 四部備要 Vol. 77 Shanghai: 中華書局, n.d. chi 集, hou chi 後集, hsu chi 續集, ying chao chi 應詔集.

TPCL: 東坡志林十二卷: 叢書集成初編 Shanghai?: 商務印書館, 1939.

TPTP: 東坡題跋: 叢書集成初編 Shanghai?: 商務印書館, 1936.

TPYF: 東坡樂府箋 上下 Preface (1957) and notes by 龍榆生. Shanghai: 商務印書館, 1958 (first edition 1936).

I. INTRODUCTION

It has very often been said that the goal of most Chinese artists and philosophers has been to achieve an "identification of the life of man with the life of nature".¹ "In China the purpose of landscape painting has been to express the identification of the painter with nature".² Perhaps it can be said that Su Shih identified himself with nature; but what this might mean is not immediately clear. What, concretely, is the "nature" that he identified with? By what process does such an identification take place, and what are the intermediate steps? Can we still speak of such an identification if we conceive, as is usual today,³ of the self as having its origin in social relations? What is it that actually happens to the self, and if it is changed, is the change reflected again in attitudes toward or relations with society?

Often, this involvement of Chinese thinkers with the natural world has been interpreted as mere escapism. Thus a new interest in nature in the third and fourth centuries A.D. is considered to be part of a general

1. Laurence Binyon, The Flight of the Dragon (New York: Grove Press, 1961), p. 16.

2. Holmes Welch, The Parting of the Way: Lao-tze and the Taoist Movement (Boston: Beacon Press, 1957), p. 159. Cf. also Fung Yu-lan, A Short History of Chinese Philosophy (New York: Macmillan, 1948), p. 6; Derk Bodde, "Harmony and Conflict in Chinese Philosophy", in Arthur F. Wright, ed., Studies in Chinese Thought (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1953), pp. 54ff.; Y. P. Mei, "Man and Nature in Chinese Philosophy" in H. Frenz and G. L. Anderson, eds., Indiana University Conference on Oriental-Western Literary Relations (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1955), pp. 151-160, especially p. 158; and many others.

3. For example, in Anselm Strauss, ed., The Social Psychology of George Herbert Mead (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1956), p. 217; Kimball Young, Social Psychology, 3rd edition (New York: Appleton-Century-Crofts, 1956), pp. 118 and 123, and Theodore M. Newcomb; Social Psychology (New York: Dryden Press, 1950), p. 316.

attitude of pleasure-seeking and social disengagement among intellectuals;⁴ and, in discussing Su Shih's own time, one author writes of a flight to nature of souls exhausted by a hopeless struggle against the forces of social and political decline.⁵ Like the statements about the sage's identification with nature, such explanations as these are too vague and too general to be satisfying.

Su Shih (1036-1101), an unusually versatile and gifted man of the Northern Sung Dynasty (960-1126), was profoundly rooted in the Chinese traditional civilization, yet at the same time capable of reevaluating and contributing to it. He was intensely interested in natural landscapes, and deeply involved in his society. As an official, he had a strong conception of social role and duty, a highly developed social self. His relations to the non-social, natural landscape grew out of a general inclination in Chinese thought to regard the natural world as essentially like the human world, rather than as opposite to it; thus the natural world could give him information about himself just as human relations could. But, influenced in part by Buddhist and Taoist ideas, Su Shih found in the natural world no evidence of selves, his own or any other; on the contrary, the natural landscape appeared as artist and work of art together, an entire spontaneity and absence of attachment which seemed to him to argue

4. Nagasawa Kikuya, *Geschichte der Chinesischen Literatur* (Hildesheim: Georg Olms, 1960), p. 149; Etienne Balazs, "Entre Révolte Nihiliste et Evasion Mystique: Les Courants Intellectuels en Chine au IIIe Siècle de notre Ere", *Etudes Asiatiques*, Vol. 2 (1948), p. 34; Murakami Yoshimi, "Hermit Life (In-itsu) of Tung Chin Period", *The Shirin of the Journal of History*, Vol. 39 (1956), pp. 21-39 (461-499), English Summary.

5. W. Eichhorn, "Überblick der gesellschaftlichen Lage der nördlichen Sung-Dynastie", *Sinica*, Vol. 13 (1938), p. 18. Osvald Siren says that Su Shih found refuge from adversity in his intimacy with nature (*Chinese Painting*, Vol. II (New York: Ronald,), p. 12).

that man's true nature, too, is artistic and without self. He would not reject either the social world or the natural world, and his writings reflect a continuing tension between them. The ideal solution which he saw, but was not always able to practice in the political circumstances of his later years, was to be a responsible official, as if the social self were real, but at the same time to retain the spontaneity and detachment he found in the landscape experience, as if the social self were unreal.

In times of rapid change it is not surprising that previously accepted interpretations of the relations between the natural world, society, and the self are no longer felt to be fully relevant or convincing. The Northern Sung was such a period, and so is the present century in much of the world. Today we return again and again to this basic triangle of self, group, world, believing that we cannot well understand any of them without understanding how it stands with the other two. And we need to understand them, because the relations among them seem disturbed and imperfect-- the self often seems alienated from the group, the group from the world, the world from the self. Why should it annoy us to find sandwich wrappings and beer cans in the woods? Why do some people fight to preserve wilderness areas or whooping cranes? Is it hate of man, or love for "unspoiled nature"? How should we behave toward the wildernesses we may find on other planets, and why do we want to go there in the first place?

There is much to be gained from studying the understanding of some of the relations among the three corners of this triangle achieved by a man like Su Shih against the background of one of the world's richest civilizations; his problems resemble ours enough to be germane, yet are unlike enough to give us an indispensable perspective on him, and through him, on ourselves as well. But we cannot do this by noting such generalities as

that the sage identifies with the universe, and the artist with his landscape; or that Chinese intellectuals turned to nature to escape society--so do we as tourists in our state parks. We must be willing to examine the details of the actual behavior (including thought and art) of real people like Su Shih, with whatever sources we have, and with all the concreteness of which we are capable; we cannot look at our own situation from outside unless we can make the outside vantage-point a genuine and humanly plausible one in itself. Otherwise we risk simply projecting our concerns as phantasies on a screen of our own making.

Method and relation to geography.

Geography may be the study of, not the earth's surface, but man. "The geographical conception is in the last analysis a kind of philosophy of man considered as the principal inhabitant of the planet."⁶ Therefore the end-point of a geographic study may be statements about man, not about the external world. The reason that such a study can belong to geography lies in the aspect of man that it focuses upon: its emphasis is on man not as one who lives in groups, like sociology; not as one who lives in states, like political science; not as one who expresses himself in art, like aesthetics; not as one who produces and consumes things of value, like economics; not as an organism subject to malfunction and disease, like medicine;--although it may draw upon all of these and more, still its own goal and end-point are man as he lives, singly and in groups, upon the planet. In terms of the triangle of society, self, (physical) world, a

6. Andre Cholley, Guide de l'Etudiant en Géographie (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1942), p. 121; quoted and translated in Richard Hartshorne, Perspective on the Nature of Geography (Chicago: Rand McNally, 1959), p. 44.

study such as this one is properly geographic in that it is concerned with some of the relations between the world and the other two. The general approach of geography to man is further subdivided in the various branches of geography, each one having its more special outlook on the world as man's home. Thus, for example, the world may be seen, as a whole or in its parts, as economic resources connected by transport routes; as a patchwork of political sovereignties; as a breeding ground for diseases; as an inspiration and raw material for works of art; or, as in this thesis, as a field for the discovery and exploration of the self.⁷

Implicit in this conception of geography is the assumption that man and his natural environment can be thought of separately, and as Toynbee says, "To draw the vulgar distinction between Man and his environment is scientifically inadmissible;"⁸ and, "I admit that I have misrepresented Reality in drawing my distinctions between . . . environment and Man" "But," as he adds, "the price of restoring to Reality its true undifferentiated unity is to renounce the possibility of thinking about it . . ."⁹ Artificial it is to separate them, but useful too as long as no one is fooled. In the light of this "undifferentiated unity," the question of whether or not the environment is "real" also appears as irrelevant. If we are real, the environment is real too; and what would it mean to claim that

7. For approaches to geography from a psychological viewpoint see, for example, Willy Hellpach, Geopsyche: Die Menschenseele unterm Einfluss von Wetter und Klima, Boden und Landschaft (Leipzig: Wilhelm Engelmann, 1935), passim; and Maximilien Sorre, Géographie Psychologique, Book 6, Chapter 3 (separate volume) of Henri Piéron, ed., Traité de Psychologie Appliquée (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1954), passim.

8. Arnold J. Toynbee, A Study of History, Vol. XII, Reconsiderations (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1961), p. 148.

9. Ibid., pp. 258-259.

neither we nor it are real? something is there.

Somewhat the same may be said of the concept of self. Watts argues convincingly that it is a social fiction,¹⁰ and Su Shih seems to arrive at the same conclusion.¹¹ But in human experience the self often appears as an entity having real existence, and to use the concept opens up fruitful lines of thought. It would be more accurate to consider the self as a pattern of relations between individual and society, and individual and the natural world; but it is convenient to treat it as a real thing, and again, if no one is fooled, no harm need be done.

Harold and Margaret Sprout have done a beautiful job of summing up and criticizing the various ideas geographers and others have had of the relationships between man and his natural environment.¹² In their terms, the methodological framework of this thesis is "cognitive behaviorism," which they define as "the hypothesis . . . that a person reacts to his milieu as he apperceives it--i.e., as he perceives and interprets it in the light of his previous knowledge."¹³ This approach, they say, "is well established in the theory and practice of historiography," and they find it also in geographic writings by Lucien Febvre, H. J. Mackinder, K.G.T. Clark,

10. Alan W. Watts, Psychotherapy East and West (New York: Pantheon Books (Mentor), 1963), passim, especially chapter 2. See also Percival M. Symonds, The Ego and the Self (New York: Appleton-Century-Crofts, 1951), p. 16.

11. See below, chapters III, IV, and V.

12. Harold Sprout and Margaret Sprout, Man-Milieu Relationship Hypotheses in the Context of International Politics (Princeton: Center of International Studies, Princeton University, copyright 1956), passim.

13. Ibid., p. 58. See also Robert K. Merton, "The Self-fulfilling Prophecy," Antioch Review, Vol. 8 (1948), pp. 193-210.

and William Kirk.¹⁴

The Sprouts consider that "the cognitive behavioral approach to man-milieu relationships is relevant and useful. But no more than environmental possibilism of which they also approve does it provide a comprehensive frame of reference."¹⁵ On the one hand, there is much evidence that the ideas people have of the world do often correspond closely with the real world (people who consider themselves insular generally live on islands); on the other hand, unperceived things in the real world may have to be taken into account in explaining what actually happens. The limits of both "environmental possibilism" and "cognitive behaviorism", taken separately, are made clear in an illustration the Sprouts have given earlier:

A man enters an unlighted street in total darkness. Techniques of behavioral analysis may be helpful in explaining how he happens to be there (i.e., his motivation and purposes), how he conceives the layout of the street to be (i.e., his cognition of the milieu), and how he gropes his way forward in the darkness (i.e., his decisions and implementing actions). But there is an open manhole in his path. He does not know it is there. He cannot perceive it in the darkness. It forms no part of the apperceived milieu to which his decisions are oriented. Nevertheless, that manhole is a strategic factor in his milieu, for he will fall into it if he continues his present course. The unperceived factor sets limits in the results, or consequences, of the man's decisions and implementing actions. These limits operate irrespective of his cognition of them in advance. Indeed his ignorance of the unperceived factor makes it all the more strategic, since his ignorance excludes the possibility of his taking adaptive counter-action.¹⁶

The Sprouts are writing specifically from the point of view of international politics; they are interested in the techniques of explaining what has

14. Harold Sprout and Margaret Sprout, Man-Milieu Relationship Hypotheses in the Context of International Politics (Princeton: Center of International Studies, Princeton University, copyright 1956), pp. 59-63.

15. Ibid., p. 71.

16. Ibid., p. 46.

happened or predicting what is likely to happen in this context. Therefore they cannot ignore either the real milieu (including the open man-hole) nor the man's erroneous conception of the milieu: what happens will grow out of both these worlds as they interact. The "cognitive behaviorist" study of the man's idea and the "environmental possibilist" study of the real milieu must supplement each other.

Neither political scientists nor geographers can study all the internal and external conditions necessary for complete explanations of human events. Behind any convincing general explanation of why more people live in a particular plain than in the adjacent mountains there must be many less ambitious special studies of crops, settlement types, climates, military geography, distributions of soils and vegetations, birth and death rates, reasons for past migrations, etc. Without these, the general statements remain at the level of hypotheses or guesses. And one of the more specialized approaches that, whether implicit or explicit, must underlie any general explanation in human geography is that of cognitive behaviorism: its contribution is the analysis of what the people involved think of their milieu. Thus the cognitive behaviorist approach, as the Sprouts make clear, must at the very least be part of any complete explanation of human events.

But there is another aspect of what the Sprouts call cognitive behaviorism which they neglect, perhaps because they do not think it relevant to their context of international politics. The purpose of studying man-milieu relationships need not be to explain or predict human events at all: it can also be to increase self-knowledge--i.e., by sympathetic imaginative participation in a wide range of human situations to expand one's understanding of how people (oneself as well as others) can and do feel, think,

and act. This is the position of R.G. Collingwood, whom the Sprouts cite as an example of a cognitive behaviorist, stating that "many, perhaps most, historians would agree in principle" with the passage they give. Collingwood writes about history, but to him history is "the science of human affairs",¹⁷ an umbrella broad enough to cover the subject-matter of all the social sciences, including human geography. Collingwood argues eloquently that "all history is the history of thought"; "you are thinking historically . . . when you say about anything, 'I see what the person who made this (wrote this, used this, designed this &c.) was thinking.'"¹⁸ And farther on he writes,

If what the historian knows is past thoughts, and if he knows them by re-thinking them himself, it follows that the knowledge he achieves by historical inquiry is not knowledge of his situation as opposed to knowledge of himself, it is a knowledge of his situation which is at the same time knowledge of himself. In re-thinking what somebody else thought, he thinks it himself. In knowing that somebody else thought it, he knows that he himself is able to think it. And finding out what he is able to do is finding out what kind of a man he is. If he is able to understand, by re-thinking them, the thoughts of a great many different kinds of people, it follows that he must be a great many kinds of man. He must be, in fact, a microcosm of all the history he can know. Thus his own self-knowledge is at the same time his knowledge of the world of human affairs.¹⁹

It is obvious that man-milieu relationships may be studied in this way, as history of thought and for the general purpose of "self-knowledge", just like the examples of historical subject-matters that Collingwood gives elsewhere: politics, warfare, economic activity, morals, art, science, religion, philosophy, and so forth.²⁰

17. R. G. Collingwood, An Autobiography (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1939), p. 115.

18. Ibid., p. 110.

19. Ibid., pp. 114-115.

20. R. G. Collingwood, The Idea of History, (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1946), pp. 309ff.

And in fact many geographers have, in one way or another, practiced or defended this approach, though not so clearly and consciously as Collingwood. Alexander von Humboldt's Kosmos contains a lengthy section (in Book II-A) on the poetic description of nature and on landscape painting, which he takes to show the reflection of the outside world in the minds of men, and considers intrinsically a valid part of his "physical description of the world;" he also thinks these topics important as means of arousing interest in the study of "nature," i.e., the external world. Carl Sauer touches on Collingwood's approach when he writes, "One might say that he [the historical geographer] needs the ability to see the land with the eyes of its former occupants, from the standpoint of their needs and capacities It is . . . a rewarding experience to know that one has succeeded in penetrating a culture that is removed in time or alien in content from ours;"²¹ however, Sauer's main overt emphasis is not here. G. R. Lowther²² compares "Positivist" "Idealist" methodology, which correspond roughly with the Sprouts' and Collingwood's approaches, respectively; but he considers Idealism "esoteric," and while he (like the Sprouts) finds the two methodologies complementary, his sympathies seem to lie with the goals of Positivist thought. He refers to R. H. Brown's Historical Geography of the United States and Mirror for Americans among other examples of an Idealist approach to historical geography. David

21. Carl O. Sauer, "Foreward to Historical Geography," Annals of the Association of American Geographers, Vol. 31 (1941), p. 10.

22. G. R. Lowther, "Idealist History and Historical Geography", The Canadian Geographer, No. 14 (1959), pp. 31-36.

Lowenthal in his "Geography, Experience, and Imagination",²³ while he says he is not discussing ". . . the meaning or methods of geography, but rather . . . the theory of geographical knowledge",²⁴ still by the very fact of his writing such a paper clearly considers that the study of geographical knowledge, or thought about the earth, is within the province of geographers. And Richard Hartshorne is referring to something very much like Collingwood's view when he writes, of the "common-sense justification of geography", "Geography as a chorographic (or chorologic) study has always found its justification in the widespread desire of many people to know what other parts of the world are like, just as history finds ample justification in the common desire to know what happened and what things were like in past times."²⁵ What other places or other times are "like", a deliberately vague phrase, suggests a sharing of the experiences or a "re-thinking the thoughts" of people at those places and times.

Thus it seems reasonable to distinguish at least two possible purposes for studying man-milieu relationships: one (the one which interests the Sprouts), to arrive at explanations (or, which is essentially the same thing, predictions) of human events, where what people think they are doing and the milieu they think they are in is only part of the story; and another (like Collingwood's view of history), to increase self-knowledge and hence knowledge of man in general by re-thinking past thoughts, where the possibilities of the milieu and their connection with what actually happens

23. David Lowenthal, "Geography, Experience, and Imagination: Towards a Geographical Epistemology", Annals of the American Association of Geographers, Vol. 51 (1961), pp. 241-260.

24. Ibid., p. 241, note 2.

25. Richard Hartshorne, "The Nature of Geography: A Critical Survey of Current Thought in the Light of the Past", Annals of the Association of American Geographers, Vol. 29 (1939), p. 130.

are only of secondary importance. The Sprouts' goal may perhaps someday be partially attained by the application of formulas programmed on computers which will deliver answers within acceptable limits of probability, without anyone's having to re-think the thoughts involved. There is nothing wrong with this in itself; but it does not have nor can it ever have primary relevance to the "science of human affairs" as Collingwood means it. At most, it could be an aid in reconstructing past thoughts and in plotting the limits of human freedom, just as, on the other side, cognitive behaviorism is an aid in explaining human events but is not in itself sufficient to do so completely.

This thesis, then, is intended in the spirit of an idealist geography, like Collingwood's history, and thus its subject matter is ultimately human thought. What makes it geography is that, within the "science of human affairs", this thought is about man in respect to an aspect of his living upon this planet, or an aspect of the world as man's home.

This aspect is suggested by the word "landscape" as used in terms of "landscape painting" and "landscape poetry".²⁶

As Toynbee says, man and environment really form an undifferentiated whole, but must be separated if thinking is to progress. Similarly, Sorre points out that the environment in man's experience is whole, but it must be studied in parts if we are to advance our knowledge of the relations

26. According to the unabridged Oxford International Dictionary, "landscape" was originally a painters' term, and its first meaning is "a picture representing inland scenery, as dist. from a sea picture, a portrait, etc." Other meanings include "inland natural scenery" and "a prospect of inland scenery, such as can be taken in at a glance from one point of view; a piece of country scenery."

between man and environment.²⁷ "Landscape", in the very limited sense in which it is used in this thesis, is a part of man's environment, and like other similar terms (such as "resource", "boundary", "route"), it makes sense only if it is understood as a human interpretation of environment, and is considered in its relations to man. This kind of "landscape" means simply the parts of the actual, known world which are relatively unsocialized: where the surface of the earth appears relatively unmodified by man, and where occupancy, especially by men in groups, is relatively sparse. The most prominent, the dominating objects in such areas are natural objects--rocks, trees, hills, streams. Their strongest contrast is with the densely socialized space of cities, and it seems that cities have been a prerequisite for the emergence of "landscape" as a distinct category of human experience.²⁸

This limited and specific meaning of "landscape" is not, of course, the one that geographers have usually attached to the word.²⁹ Unfortunately

27. Maximilien Sorre, Géographie psychologique, Book 6, chapter 3 (separate volume) of Henri Piéron, ed., Traité de Psychologie Appliquée (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1954), p. 2.

28. Cf. Edwin O. Reischauer and John K. Fairbank, A History of East Asian Civilization, Vol. 1, East Asia: The Great Tradition (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1960), p. 224. Northern Sung cities are discussed briefly below.

29. Richard Hartshorne, in "The Nature of Geography: A Critical Survey of Current Thought in the Light of the Past", Annals of the Association of American Geographers, Vol. 29 (1939), chapter 5 ("Landschaft" and "Landscape"), summarizes the use of the term "landscape" in geography, especially in Germany and the United States. He would probably not condone my usage. He eliminates, as far as geography is concerned, the meaning "view of an area as seen in perspective", and also says, "Presumably most geographers will likewise have little or no use for any concepts based on our psychic sensations of area." (p. 160). If this were so, too bad for geography!

there seems to be no other convenient term referring to "relatively un-socialized parts of the world." "Nature" is a possibility, but it has too many other meanings.³⁰ Other expressions which might do, like "non-socialized physical universe as apperceived by man" are too long and dull. "Landscape", at any rate, is clear enough so that the reader need never be in doubt about what is meant.

So this thesis is a study of the non-socialized "landscapes" of 11th-century China as Su Shih experienced them. As his experience was rich and subtle, and he writes very well, it is worth while to try to follow his thoughts, arranging them so that they become intelligible and plausible to us in the 20th century, and can be part of our own experience.

But first it will be helpful to take a closer look at Northern Sung China and at Su Shih's life, and to become acquainted with some of the background to Sung thought on landscapes.

China in the Northern Sung Dynasty

The life of Su Shih (1036-1101) lies in the second half of the Northern Sung dynasty (960-1126), a period in which many characteristics of Chinese culture took the form they were to retain until 1911. Although the roots of these go back at least several centuries, they were developed, selected, strengthened, and integrated in the Northern Sung to produce a civilization that looks more like the China of 900 years later than that of 400 years earlier. Su Shih, like the rest of his generation, had to take these new conditions into account in working out his conception of the relations

30. See A. O. Lovejoy and G. Boas, A Documentary History of Primitivism and Related Ideas, Vol. 1, Primitivism and Related Ideas in Antiquity (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1935), pp. 447-456, where, without claim to completeness, sixty-six senses of the word "nature" are distinguished.

between himself, society, and the natural world, and the ideas of earlier thinkers were only partly relevant. His own thinking, on the other hand, had continuing relevance through the rest of the history of dynastic China. He is a central figure in a key period of one of the world's principal civilizations.

Su Shih traveled much, but in China of the 11th century he was almost never far from unsocialized landscapes. Even two centuries later Marco Polo in his account of his travels refers again and again to the forests and the many kinds of wild animals in every part of China.³¹ China's population was only about one seventh of what it is now (it probably exceeded 100,000,000 by the beginning of the 12th century³²); and it must have been even more markedly concentrated in flat lowlands than at present, because many of the food crops (such as maize, peanuts, sweet potatoes, and Irish potatoes) which made possible the support of dense populations on sloping and infertile terrain had not yet come to China.³³ Early-ripening strains of rice, first introduced from Champa in the Indo-Chinese peninsula during the reign of Chen-tsung (998-1022), were just beginning their long diffusion and development which in later centuries were also to be associated with the bringing under cultivation of hilly and other

31. Ronald Latham, trans., The Travels of Marco Polo (Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, 1958), chapters 4 and 5.

32. Ping-ti Ho, Studies on the Population of China, 1368-1953 (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1959), Harvard East Asian Studies No. 4, p. 172.

33. Ibid., pp. 169ff.

marginal land.³⁴ The neglect of uplands and slopes for farming³⁵ meant that a short walk would take a man away from society among woods and streams where, at most, he might meet a solitary woodcutter, fisherman, or hermit.

Thus it would not be true to describe 11th-century China in the same terms Cressey uses for 20th-century China:

. . . The landscape everywhere reflects the intensity of man's occupance Everywhere there are human beings. In this old, old land, one can scarcely find a spot unmodified by man and his activities.³⁶

At the same time, Northern Sung China was by no means only a collection of farming villages set in a wilderness. This period saw the beginning of the massive population growth which, with interruptions, has reached right up to the present.³⁷ Even more important in the short run were the transformation and the growth of cities, and the increasing urbanization of parts of the society. The populations of a number of cities probably passed the million mark,³⁸ and the gentry class (see below, p. 20)

34. Ibid., pp. 170ff.

35. "There is evidence that the dry hills and mountains of the Yangtze region and north China were still largely virgin about 1700" (Ibid., p. 184). See also Pierre Gourou, "Notes on China's Unused Uplands", Pacific Affairs, Vol. 21 (1948), pp. 227-238.

36. George B. Cressey, Asia's Lands and Peoples (New York: McGraw-Hill, second edition 1951), p. 34.

37. Ping-ti-Ho, Studies on the Population of China, 1368-1953 (Cambridge, Mass.; Harvard University Press, 1959), Harvard East Asian Studies No. 4, p. 176: ". . . in terms of food supply, China's population could probably increase, and apparently did begin to increase substantially, from 1000 onward."

38. Edward A. Kracke, Civil Service in Early Sung China (960-1067) (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1953), Harvard-Yenching Institute Monograph Series, Vol. 13, p. 13.

typically lived in cities rather than on their lands. There was also a burgeoning of private commerce, domestic and foreign, centered in the cities. Cities began to take on the aspect they were to retain into the 20th century, with varied business and government activities, and all kinds of entertainment, including restaurants, brothels, theaters, and tea shops. Most of the cities of the new kind were in the Yangtze valley and along the south-east coast, and there was a general shift in the center of gravity of the civilization toward the south; in the middle of the Northern Sung, degree-holders and officials from the South began to outnumber those from the North.³⁹ The amount of money coined increased greatly, and paper money began to be widely used. Merchants were less looked down upon than they had been in earlier periods.⁴⁰

There was a broad development of literature in the Northern Sung. The leading writers favored the use of "old-style" prose (ku-wen), which stylistically was a rejection of the highly mannered writing which had been prevalent since the third century, and a preference for the simpler (although still not vernacular) prose of earlier times; but the ku-wen movement went

39. James T.C. Liu, Reform in Sung China: Wang An-shih (1021-1086) and his New Policies (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1959), p. 37. On other aspects of the cultural development of the South in this period, see P' an Kuang-tan, "The Distribution, Migrations, and Inheritance of Chinese Painters" (潘光旦: 中國畫家的分佈, 移植, 與遺傳), 人文月刊, Vol. 1 (1930), pp. 1-15; Vol. 2 (1931), pp. 17-31; and Ho Yu-sen, "The Geographical Distribution of Schools of Thought in the Northern and Southern Sung Dynasties" (何佑森: 兩宋學風的地理分佈), 新亞學報, Vol. 1 (1955), pp. 331-379.

40. See Edwin O. Reischauer and John K. Fairbank, A History of East Asian Civilization, Vol. 1, East Asia: The Great Tradition (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1960), pp. 221-225 for an excellent summary of Sung society and economy.